Decoding ISO 9001 2026 Clause 6 Planning

Risks opportunities objectives and controlled change



Turn uncertainty and ambition into actions whose effectiveness can be evaluated.

Expanded practitioner edition for IMS managers, engineers and leadership teams

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Using this publication

Turn uncertainty and ambition into actions whose effectiveness can be evaluated.

This expanded practitioner edition explains every numbered subclause within Clause 6 of the supplied ISO 9001:2026 text. It develops the earlier RPG collected technical insights into a standalone working guide with operational examples, role applications, two reusable worksheets and two printable poster annexes.

Requirements and recommendations

The required outcomes are original paraphrases of the supplied standard. Its informative Annex A clarifies meaning without adding requirements. Practical methods, scenarios, sample sizes, worksheet fields, review periods and poster prompts in this book are RPG recommendations, unless a requirement is expressly identified. Use a licensed copy for the complete normative text. [1]

How to read it

Begin with the working language and coverage route. Read the relevant clause interpretation, then follow one real process with its owner. Use the cases to challenge your reasoning and the worksheets to record a decision. The annexes can support team discussion; they are not exhaustive audit checklists.

Technical basis

Supporting referrals were checked against official public publication records on 8 November 2026. Many APG papers and ISO/TS 9002:2016 address the earlier edition. Use them only where consistent with the 2026 requirement. ISO 9000 supplies the normative vocabulary referral. Other supporting publications do not automatically expand ISO 9001 requirements.

All organisations, events and figures in the cases are fictional teaching examples. They are not customer results, statistical benchmarks or promised savings. Photographs are illustrative. This guide does not establish certification or replace applicable technical, contractual or legal assessment.

Working language and practical translation

These are plain English working explanations, not formal quotations or replacements for ISO 9000 definitions. The application column shows the decision each term should help a reader make.

Term	Working explanation	Practical translation
Risk	Uncertainty with a possible adverse effect on the intended quality result.	Describe the scenario rather than only its score.
Opportunity	A circumstance that can enable a beneficial quality result.	State the positive outcome and how it will be evaluated.
Objective	A defined result the organisation intends to achieve.	Distinguish the outcome from the project activity.
Proportionate	Suited to the significance and consequence of the matter.	Explain why the depth of action fits the problem.
Implementation	Putting the chosen arrangement into operation.	Establish that the action was actually carried out.
Effectiveness	The extent to which the intended result is achieved.	Choose evidence that tests the purpose of the action.

Read the verbs carefully

A requirement calls for fulfilment. Guidance suggests a possible approach. Thinking about an issue differs from incorporating it into a decision. Suitability depends on the organisation’s context, while applicability concerns whether a requirement is relevant to the situation. The supplied Annex A.2 and the vocabulary referrals help resolve these distinctions. [1]

Do not turn a preferred template, score or software workflow into a requirement simply because it is familiar. Equally, do not use flexible wording to avoid an outcome the standard actually requires.

Clause coverage and reading route

The references below cover every numbered subclause within this book’s main clause. Where related subclauses share a page, their required outcomes are distinguished in the text. Parent headings organise the requirements and are included in this coverage.

Covered references	Interpretation section
6.1, 6.1.1	6.1.1 Determine what needs a planning response
6.1.2	6.1.2 Analyse risks and test the response
6.1.3	6.1.3 Give opportunities a defined beneficial result
6.2, 6.2.1, 6.2.2	6.2 Objectives and a plan capable of achieving them
6.3	6.3 Plan a change through to its review

The question to carry through the book

Can you explain the desired result separately from the risk you are trying to reduce?

Read across the system

Clause interpretation supports a working process. It does not require the organisation’s manuals, software modules or department structure to mirror the numbering of the standard. The links to other clauses in this book help preserve that systems perspective. [1, A.1, A.2]

6.1.1 Determine what needs a planning response

Required outcome

Use the context and relevant requirements established under Clause 4 to determine the risks and opportunities that need attention. The purpose is confidence in intended QMS results, fewer unwanted effects, continual improvement and stronger beneficial results. [1, A.6.1.1]

Practical translation

An issue is a condition; a risk describes an uncertain adverse effect; an opportunity describes a circumstance that could support a beneficial result. These distinctions help people choose actions with a clear purpose. Risks and opportunities can be linked without being interchangeable.

Application in the work

A shortage of specialist capacity is an issue. The possible inability to complete a required review is a risk. Access to a validated remote review capability may present an opportunity. Evaluate the implications for conformity, customer satisfaction, information protection and practical competence before assuming the proposed technology is the answer.

Evidence and judgement

Begin with the decision rather than a numerical score. State what result matters, what may prevent or improve it, the available evidence and the uncertainty. Connect the subsequent response to a process owner. A register is a useful option where it helps preserve the reasoning.

Avoid this mistake

A formal risk management framework, a specific matrix and a separate opportunity register are not universal ISO 9001 requirements. Listing a topic without a decision about its relevance is weak evidence of planning.

Guidance referral

A.6.1.1 distinguishes risks and opportunities. ISO 31000:2018 is an optional referral for a more extensive risk approach. [4]

6.1.2 Analyse risks and test the response

Required outcome

Determine, analyse and evaluate risks that could undermine consistent conforming products or services and customer satisfaction. Plan appropriate actions, integrate them into the QMS processes and evaluate their effectiveness. The response must be proportionate to the potential effect on intended results. Disruption can be relevant to consistent provision. [1, A.6.1.2]

Practical translation

Risk assessment is a reasoned judgement about uncertainty and consequence. A risk score is a compressed representation of that judgement. It is useful only if the underlying scenario, assumptions and response can be explained.

Application in the work

An engineering team depends on one specialist for a critical review. Consider absence duration, alternative competence, work demand and the consequence of an incorrect or late decision. The response might combine competence development, controlled external support and revised acceptance of work. Giving the risk a lower score because training is scheduled does not show that capability exists.

Evidence and judgement

Define the evidence that would demonstrate the response works, such as a competent deputy completing a representative task under the approved conditions. Review actual operation after implementation. Examine disruptive scenarios against realistic recovery capability, not solely against a continuity plan title.

Avoid this mistake

Implementation and effectiveness are different. A lower score entered by the action owner is not independent evidence that exposure reduced. Nor is every risk removable; informed retention still needs a defensible decision within the applicable boundaries.

Guidance referral

A.6.1.2 explains that formal risk methods are not imposed. ISO 31000 provides broader guidance but does not add mandatory steps to ISO 9001. [4]

6.1.3 Give opportunities a defined beneficial result

Required outcome

Determine, analyse and evaluate opportunities that could improve consistent conformity and customer satisfaction. Plan the actions, their integration into operating processes and evaluation of effectiveness. The response must suit the organisation’s context and support the intended beneficial results. [1, A.6.1.3]

Practical translation

Reducing a threat can create a benefit, but an opportunity deserves a positive proposition of its own. Specify what will improve, for whom, and how that result will be recognised. An idea, an installed system and a realised benefit are three different states.

Application in the work

A digital review route may allow earlier customer clarification. Define the desired improvement in the time to a correct accepted requirement, not merely the number of digital forms completed. Review competence, data quality, exceptions and information security as conditions of the opportunity. A faster incorrect decision is not the intended gain.

Evidence and judgement

An opportunity record can state the baseline, proposal, responsible sponsor, resources, expected result, constraints and evaluation period. These are practical planning fields. Test unintended effects and compare a fair population before presenting a benefit. A decision to defer can be appropriate when evidence or resources are insufficient.

Avoid this mistake

Do not fill the opportunity column only with the opposite wording of each risk. Nor should every improvement idea become a funded project. The organisation needs proportionate analysis and a justified response, not a universal financial threshold.

Guidance referral

A.6.1.3 explains potential opportunity sources. ISO 10014:2021 offers guidance on connecting quality actions with business results. [5]

6.2 Objectives and a plan capable of achieving them

Required outcome

Under 6.2.1, establish documented measurable quality objectives at relevant levels, functions and processes. Keep them consistent with policy, applicable requirements, conformity and customer satisfaction. Monitor, communicate and update them as appropriate. Under 6.2.2, determine the work, resources, responsibility, completion timing and evaluation of results needed to achieve them. [1]

Practical translation

An objective states the result sought. An implementation plan explains how the business expects to reach it. A task such as installing software can support an objective but does not, by itself, state a better quality result.

Application in the work

A suggested objective is to reduce accepted orders entering delivery with unresolved requirements, while maintaining an agreed acceptance time. Define the population, baseline, numerator, denominator and handling of exceptions. The balancing measure tests whether the new acceptance control creates an unacceptable delay elsewhere.

Evidence and judgement

Use a documented objective and an accountable plan that can be followed into the work. A qualitative result can be measurable where the criteria for judging achievement are explicit and repeatable. Check whether the relevant people know the objective and whether management acts when resources or assumptions change.

Avoid this mistake

A SMART format is an optional aid, not a named requirement. A green dashboard based on a redefined denominator may create a misleading appearance of achievement. Changes to a measure need a transparent explanation.

Guidance referral

A.6.2 explains objectives in an integrated system. ISO 10014 supports the management interpretation of results; it does not prescribe the target. [5]

6.3 Plan a change through to its review

Required outcome

When the QMS needs to change, implement the change in a planned way. Consider its purpose and consequences, system integrity, resources and information, responsibility and authority, communication, monitoring and evaluation of effectiveness, and review of the results. [1, A.6.3]

Practical translation

A change is not complete merely because equipment is installed or a new workflow is switched on. The decision includes whether the changed arrangement can operate correctly, whether its interfaces remain coherent and whether the intended result has been achieved.

Application in the work

For a move to remote technical review, check access to controlled information, competence, customer restrictions, decision authority, record integrity and arrangements when the connection fails. Set conditions for implementation and a review of representative completed work. Scale the method to the change; not every document correction needs a major project board.

Evidence and judgement

A practical change record connects the existing and proposed state, affected requirements, readiness evidence, authorised decision and subsequent result. Identify temporary arrangements and their end point. Where necessary, define a return route if the new arrangement cannot meet the agreed conditions.

Avoid this mistake

A signed change request demonstrates an approval. It does not establish operational readiness or effectiveness. A particular MOC form, fixed review period and project method are RPG options rather than additional ISO requirements.

Guidance referral

A.6.3 refers readers to ISO/TS 10020:2022 for organisational change processes. That publication supports a chosen approach and does not replace the 6.3 requirement. [6]

Apply the clause across the team

These responsibilities are recommended applications for the reader groups. The organisation still determines its own roles, competence and authority.

Reader	Contribution	Useful output
IMS manager	Link context, risks, opportunities, objectives and change controls.	A coherent planning trail and a defined effectiveness test.
Engineer	Analyse technical uncertainty and demonstrate capability of the proposed arrangement.	Assumptions, trial results and acceptance conditions.
Leadership team	Choose commitments and investment on an informed basis.	A sponsor, resources and an evidence based decision to continue, revise or stop.

Use it in an integrated management system

A common change process can bring together quality, environment, safety and security reviews. Each specialist judgement retains its own criteria and approval boundary. A financial benefit cannot by itself establish an acceptable quality, environmental or safety outcome. The integrated decision should identify conflicts rather than hide them in a combined average score.

Connections that should remain visible

Related clause	Connection to this decision
Clause 4	Planning begins with relevant conditions and requirements.
Clause 7	The plan needs real capability and suitable information.
Clause 8	Risk, opportunity and change responses must reach delivery controls.
Clauses 9 and 10	Evaluate the result and use the learning in the next decision.

Engineering case The single specialist

Fictional scenario for practical discussion

Fictional Wexford Engineering relies on one person for a technically demanding release review. A risk register describes absence risk as moderate. Management proposes to reduce the rating when a deputy attends a course.

The useful analysis establishes which decisions require competence, the expected demand and the maximum delay the business can support. A course may be part of development, but authorisation should depend on suitable evidence of competence for the actual task. Define supervised practice, assessment criteria and any limits.

A practical effectiveness review asks the deputy to complete representative reviews with controlled oversight, checks the decision quality and assesses whether the arrangement functions during the primary reviewer’s absence. The opportunity may be a more resilient and timely review service, which needs a defined beneficial result.

Leadership decides whether to change acceptance capacity or use competent external support while capability develops. The risk response is not complete merely because the training purchase is recorded.

Use the case with your team

Identify the applicable requirement, distinguish the observed facts from assumptions and decide what evidence would support the next action. Explain who has the authority and competence to make that decision. Discuss what would contradict your initial conclusion.

Your decision and the evidence still needed

Service case The digital review opportunity

Fictional scenario for practical discussion

Fictional Fenwick Services records 50 accepted jobs in a baseline period; 10 require clarification after delivery has begun. A controlled pilot records 60 accepted jobs, of which six require that clarification. These invented results produce observed rates of 20 per cent and 10 per cent.

The fall is 10 percentage points, or 50 per cent relative to the baseline rate. It is not proof that digital review caused the change. Check job mix, season, the definition of clarification and the accuracy of the records. Measure the time to a correctly accepted job as a balancing condition.

The sponsor authorises a further trial with controlled permissions, a competence check and an escalation route for ambiguous requirements. The objective concerns the quality of acceptance and customer experience, rather than the number of accounts created.

A defensible review separates the implemented process, the observed result, the remaining uncertainty and the next decision. A promising sample can support continued investigation without justifying a guaranteed savings claim.

Use the case with your team

Identify the applicable requirement, distinguish the observed facts from assumptions and decide what evidence would support the next action. Explain who has the authority and competence to make that decision. Discuss what would contradict your initial conclusion.

Your decision and the evidence still needed

Audit the decision and plan the response

The following prompts are practical aids. Define the audit criteria and scope using the applicable requirements and the organisation’s own arrangements. A prompt in this table is not a separate mandatory ISO requirement.

Subject	Question to test	Weak signal
Risk	Explain a scenario, response and effectiveness test.	A reduced score without operating evidence.
Opportunity	State the beneficial result and how it will be evaluated.	An idea or technology purchase reported as a realised benefit.
Objective	Show a documented result and an achievable resourced plan.	Task completion confused with improved performance.
Change	Show readiness, authority and review of the changed operation.	Installation or approval used as the sole closure criterion.

A focused implementation discussion

1. Choose one risk and one opportunity affecting the same process.
2. State their different adverse and beneficial effects.
3. Define the objective, action owner, resource and evaluation method.
4. Identify any change approval and review the evidence needed before closure.

Write a useful finding

Separate the criterion, what was observed and the resulting gap. Keep an improvement suggestion distinct from a nonconformity. Where immediate control is needed, use the appropriate operational authority rather than waiting for the audit report.

Record the next decision

Identify the responsible owner, the action or decision needed, the evidence of implementation and the test of effectiveness where relevant. Set timing proportionate to the issue. The organisation must determine what can proceed while uncertainty remains.

Risk and opportunity decision

Reusable RPG worksheet for internal application

Complete for one defined process or decision. Reference supporting records rather than copying a whole report. The worksheet is a suggested method; its fields are not additional requirements.

1. Context and relevant requirement

2. Adverse scenario or beneficial proposition

3. Evidence assumptions and uncertainty

4. Response owner and resources

5. Process integration and implementation condition

6. Effectiveness measure balancing check and review decision

Completion check: can another competent reviewer understand the basis, authority and limitations of the decision?

Objective and controlled change plan

Reusable RPG worksheet for internal application

Complete for one defined process or decision. Reference supporting records rather than copying a whole report. The worksheet is a suggested method; its fields are not additional requirements.

1. Result baseline and measurement definition

2. Actions resources responsibility and timing

3. Current and proposed operating arrangement

4. Readiness authority communication and dependencies

5. Effectiveness test and review of results

6. Authorised decision and outstanding actions

Completion check: can another competent reviewer understand the basis, authority and limitations of the decision?

References and publication information

Official publication records and public guidance checked on 8 November 2026. The referral notes identify scope and appropriate use; they are not full reviews of the supporting standards. Obtain the full publication where it is needed.

[1] ISO 9001:2026 Quality management systems Requirements
Primary clause basis: the supplied standard text and its informative Annex A. Open official record

[2] ISO/TS 9002:2016 Guidelines for the application of ISO 9001:2015
Earlier edition implementation guidance; check compatibility with 2026. Open official record

[3] ISO 9001 Auditing Practices Group
Supplementary audit papers, many for the 2015 edition. Open official record

[4] ISO 31000:2018 Risk management Guidelines
Optional broader risk management guidance. Open official record

[5] ISO 10014:2021 Financial and economic benefits from quality
Leadership guidance referral; published in support of earlier QMS editions. Open official record

[6] ISO/TS 10020:2022 Organisational change management Processes
Related change management processes; not automatically additional ISO 9001 criteria. Open official record

[7] ISO 9000:2026 Quality management Fundamentals and vocabulary
Normative vocabulary referral identified by ISO 9001. Open official record

[8] ISO 9000 Glossary Guidance on selected words 2025
Supporting language clarification. Use formal definitions where applicable. Open official record

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Risk and opportunity are different decisions

Practical prompts for applying the requirements. Read with the publication and the licensed standard.

01
Risk
What uncertain adverse effect needs a response?

02
Opportunity
What beneficial result could be achieved?

03
Action
What will change in the operating process?

04
Responsibility
Who owns implementation and its resources?

05
Evaluation
What would demonstrate effectiveness?

06
Decision
Continue, adjust, defer or stop on the evidence.

RPG recommended practice. These prompts do not add ISO requirements.

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Plan the change beyond installation

Practical prompts for applying the requirements. Read with the publication and the licensed standard.

01
Purpose

Define the intended result and possible consequences.

02
Integrity

Check the affected requirements and process interfaces.

03
Readiness

Provide people, information and suitable resources.

04
Authority

Assign decisions and communicate the changed arrangement.

05
Verification

Test operation and the effect on the intended result.

06
Review

Record what remains open and the next authorised decision.

RPG recommended practice. These prompts do not add ISO requirements.

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